

Jingyao Wei

PhD Candidate in Economics, Norwegian School of Economics (NHH)

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Citizenship: Chinese

Education

PhD in Economics , Norwegian School of Economics	2022–Present
Expected completion: August 2026	
Visiting Scholar, Cornell University (host: Heather Schofield)	Spring 2026
MSc in Economics , Norwegian School of Economics	2020–2022
MA in Economics of Education , Central China Normal University	2017–2020
Exchange: National Taiwan University of Science and Technology	Spring 2019
BSc in Finance , Hubei University of Economics	2010–2014
Dual-degree program: Auburn University at Montgomery, USA	2013–2014

Research Fields

Development Economics; Environmental Economics; Health Economics

Publications

Psychological Barriers to Participation in the Labor Market: Evidence from Rural Ghana

With Leandro Carvalho, Damien de Walque, Crick Lund, Heather Schofield, and Vincent Somville.

Journal of Development Economics, **181** (2026), 103734.

Abstract: Mental health conditions are strongly associated with lower labor market participation, but the underlying channels remain unclear. We conduct a two-phase study of women in rural Ghana to examine job take-up and work outcomes. In the first phase, we ask whether women would accept cash-for-work jobs during the lean season. Women with depression or anxiety are much more likely to decline work outside the home, but equally likely to accept work-from-home positions. In the second phase, we randomly offer home-based jobs to women willing to work from home. Neither depression nor anxiety predicts work completion, earnings, or quit rates. These findings suggest that barriers to accepting work outside the home help explain the association between mental health and labor market participation, and highlight home-based employment as a potential response.

Working Papers

When Solar Reaches the Poor: Forest and Health Co-Benefits in Rural China

Abstract: Solar power is expanding into poor rural areas worldwide, yet little is known about what grid-connected solar does to the communities that host it beyond producing electricity. I study China's Solar Energy Poverty Alleviation Program, which built solar stations in and around designated poverty counties and assigned registered poor households as beneficiaries. Combining the program registry with satellite forest-loss data and a national household panel, I find that forest loss within 15 kilometers of host villages fell by roughly 12 percent during the program era relative to cells farther away, and that the probability that a child's most serious recorded illness is respiratory fell by 11 percentage points, about 18 percent of the sample mean. Placebo illness categories and poverty counties without the program show no detected change. Around other detected solar plants, not matched to program villages, forest loss rose instead: the decline is specific to the program's host villages, not to solar deployment as such. The local consequences of solar investment depend on where and how it is deployed.

Working Papers (continued)

Heat, Economic Stress, and Mental Health: Evidence from Indonesia

With Simon Taye, Damien de Walque, Heather Schofield, and Hao Wang.

Abstract: Evidence on the relationship between heat and mental health varies across populations. We examine whether underlying economic stress explains this heterogeneity using panel data from Indonesia and three types of economic shocks: income losses driven by international palm oil price changes, sudden large increases in fuel costs, and job loss. In the general population, we find no association between temperature and depressive symptoms, measured using the CES-D scale, and can rule out even small harmful effects. Among those experiencing negative economic shocks, however, heat is associated with increases in depressive symptoms of 0.044–0.09 standard deviations per degree Celsius. As climate change increases both the frequency of extreme heat and the prevalence of economic shocks, our findings suggest that the psychological toll of a warming climate will be concentrated among the most economically vulnerable.

Work in Progress

The Causal Effects of Income Volatility and Income Risk

With Leandro Carvalho, Damien de Walque, Nicolas Grandstaff, Heather Schofield, and Vincent Somville.

Teaching Experience

Teaching Assistant, Norwegian School of Economics

Environmental Policy Analysis	2025
Development Economics	2024
Diversity in Firms	2024
Petroleum Economics	2023
Econometrics	2022

Presentations

European Association of Environmental and Resource Economists (EAERE), Bergen	2025
Nordic Conference in Development Economics, Gothenburg	2023

References

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